travelling to and from China were issued. The National Institute of Virology (NIV) in Pune, under the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), had begun coordinating samples for testing for nCoV. ICMR would also begin preparations immediately to isolate the virus, identify a capable indigenous company and provide the isolated strain to it in order to begin the vaccine-development process. Protocol for infection prevention and control (IPC) was prepared and communicated with the states. The Integrated Disease Surveillance Programme (IDSP) was activated in order to gear up for community surveillance and contact tracing. The status of hospital availability and preparedness was reviewed too. Also compiled was an existing inventory of medical equipment like PPE kits, masks and pharmaceutical products which would be required.[18] Notably, other countries of the world were also similarly responding to the viral threat. Reports were coming in that the United States (US) had joined the list of nations which had begun screening passengers arriving from Wuhan the same day.[19] The US's Vaccine Research Center had also initiated research on making a vaccine.[20]

Scientists have pointed out time and again that airport screenings are only useful in identifying symptomatic infected patients.[21] This works in case of viruses which display symptoms and are infectious after the onset of the symptoms like in the case of SARS or MERS. However, those viruses like SARS-CoV-2, which can become infectious even before the onset of symptoms or can be infectious even in asymptomatic hosts, can easily escape the screening system. For health systems of countries this means that although relying on temperature screenings and health advisories buys time and helps collect contact information, which is useful in surveillance and tracking, it is rarely beneficial in blocking the import of infected passengers. However, most countries brought back first responses from government memory in case of epidemics and pandemics, commencing thermal screenings, in the absence of any known behavioural pattern of the new virus.

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22 JANUARY 2020

INDIA | 0 ACTIVE CASES | 0 DEATHS